

Hong Kong's Emigration Wave:

How Exiled Hongkongers in Taiwan

View Their Homeland's Election

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This year marks the third anniversary of Hong Kong's anti-extradition movement. Three years on, how do these Hongkongers, now settled in Taiwan, view the upcoming Chief Executive election? What did that democratic struggle bring them, and what did they lose?

Tucked away in a Taipei alley, a small bookstore—revived by a new wave of immigrants—is starting a new chapter.

"This store was originally opened by Hongkongers, but the business was ending." Reluctant to see the bookstore disappear, a group of Hongkongers decided to take it over. Tsang Chi-ho, the former radio host, unexpectedly became a partner. In the store, postcards featuring Wong Tai Sin fortune slips and BNO passports replace large banners and protest imagery. One almost forgets how beautiful their homeland is.

"Hong Kong has always been rich in culture. It's not just the Hong Kong of 2019 that we know," said Tsang. Time shouldn't stop in 2019, but that year fundamentally transformed the fate of Hongkongers.

We asked Tsang why he decided to flee to Taiwan. "The trigger point was when they started arresting the group of *Apple Daily* editorial writers, because I used to write a column for Apple Daily. My job at Radio Television Hong Kong (RTHK) was also taken away around the same week. It was as if heaven made the decision for me."

Whether by fate or helplessness, he lost everything overnight and had no choice but to leave, settling in Taiwan, a place with a similar culture.

Tsang Chi-ho said his heart actually settled down after leaving Hong Kong, because he knew he was safe, at the very least.

We met another Hongkonger, Amy, who was afraid of being identified and refused to reveal her real name. "People who participated in the protests were being targeted by the government. It felt like living in a completely unfamiliar world." Amy had once considered moving to Taiwan after retiring, but the social movement forced her to move her plans forward by several years.

According to Taiwan's National Immigration Agency, more than 10,000 Hongkongers obtained residence permits in 2020—nearly double the figure from the previous year. In 2021, that number reached 11,173, including both residence and settlement permits, setting new records. The biggest driver of this surge was the 2019 anti-extradition protests in Hong Kong, coupled with the subsequent implementation of the National Security Law, which accelerated the pace of Hongkongers immigrating to Taiwan.

"This movement is masked. Everyone is a nobody. A nobody is everyone." The documentary *Revolution of Our Times*, released in February, truthfully records the struggle for democracy and freedom in Hong Kong. Taiwan, the only place in the world where the film was screened in theaters, defied pressure over its sensitive subject matter. To date, it has grossed over NT\$28 million (US\$920,000). The audience can't help but shed tears in the theater, but the protesters who were on the front lines have already cried their tears dry. Fu Tong was one of them.

"I can't cry, because it's too painful. I don't know where to start crying. The film brought back so many explosive days all at once. It was overwhelming," Fu Tong said in Mandarin that was not yet fluent. He originally ran a gym in Sheung Wan and never imagined that a simple thought on July 28, 2019, would change his and his wife's lives. On that day, the couple saw a little girl who was affected by tear gas and couldn't walk. When they helped her up, the police saw and arrested them.

They were arrested simply for trying to help. Absurdly, they were initially charged with unlawful assembly, but the next day it inexplicably became rioting, the first rioting case to be tried since the anti-extradition movement.

Fortunately, both were eventually acquitted. But instead of escaping a maximum sentence of 10 years, the most memorable part of the entire protest for them was the storming of the Legislative Council on July 1.

"Carrie Lam, step down! Carrie Lam, step down!"

That night, the five demands shouted out loud allowed Fu Tong, who was standing guard outside the Legislative Council, to deeply feel that Hongkongers had found a common goal and were becoming more united. It's just that the protest never achieved victory.

Soon after, Fu Tong found that some strangers were around his house; he knew he was being watched. Staying meant waiting to be arrested, while leaving meant abandoning his comrades. After much struggling, he reluctantly boarded a plane for Taiwan. "It was really painful. I really wanted to escape this pain. One way was to kill myself, and another was to be arrested," Fu Tong said.

The National Security Law scattered Hongkongers. Now, the changing Hong Kong is about to hold its sixth Chief Executive election. It looks very different in the eyes of Hongkongers in Taiwan.

Tsang Chi-ho ridiculed that this isn't called an election—it's called an enthronement ceremony. Liang Man-tao, a professor of political science at NCKU, is also a Hongkonger who has lived in Taiwan for years. "If the former head of the police is now the Chief Executive, is there any possibility that the police can independently investigate and enforce the law?"

Step-by-step changes are approaching because what Beijing cares about is not the people but the interests and power that this land brings.

"The most important thing is political stability, so for them people are not important; the important thing is this place. In the future, they want to control it thoroughly. The current situation in Hong Kong is indeed very worrying."

The initial fears have come true one by one. Looking back at the homeland they can't return to, these exiles in Taiwan have no regrets.

Tsang Chi-ho pointed out that the process of waking up is very important. Now they know that it's impossible to ask a tiger for its skin. They would rather wake up in pain than live a humble life. The fire of the National Security Law has almost burned down Hong Kong's democracy and rule of law, but it has also brought rebirth.

"We are now like farmers holding seeds. Those seeds are the strengths that Hongkongers should have. We must protect those strengths, and it's best to return to Hong Kong and scatter those seeds. That's another hope," Fu Tong said, with a faint smile on his face. Clutching the seeds of hope, the spirit of the times follows overseas Hongkongers, blossoming everywhere. They patiently wait for the day glory returns to Hong Kong.